

## KOLAVERI DI

Before algorithms and campaigns took over, in 2011, *'Kolaveri Di'* slipped into everyday life, shared on phones, hummed in hostels, played on loop without anyone pushing it. It showed, for the first time, how a song could travel purely by word of mouth in the internet age and still take over the country






## TVF AND AIB

TVF and AIB quietly rewrote the rules on YouTube. They laid the cultural and creative foundations for India's OTT revolution that would soon follow

ROHIT CHAWLA



REUTERS

## ASH & ABHISHEK

In April 2007, Bollywood's 'royalty' Abhishek Bachchan and Aishwarya Rai married in a high-profile wedding that captivated the nation

Yet this dominance also masked a creative churn beneath, where new directors, technicians and writers quietly reshaped the language of cinema. The early signs of digital disruption emerged almost accidentally. In 2011, *'Kolaveri Di'* became India's first viral YouTube sensation, bypassing traditional music labels and film marketing altogether. It revealed a generational shift in consumption, where screens were smaller, access was instant and popularity was algorithm-driven. By 2012, early digital collectives like TVF and AIB were laying the foundations of India's OTT ecosystem, experimenting with short-form storytelling that spoke directly to urban youth, unconstrained by censorship or star hierarchies.

By 2014, Indian cinema stood at a crossroads—it was confronting audience fatigue, rising costs and creative risk aversion. The old certainties of stardom still held, but new voices were gathering at the edges. While full-fledged streaming platforms would reshape viewing habits after 2015, the cultural groundwork was laid during this decade. Audiences were already fragmenting, attention spans shrinking and content creators learning to speak to niches rather than masses. Cinema's monopoly over popular storytelling was ending, even if its cultural authority remained intact.

The years between 2005 and 2014 thus represent Indian cinema's great in-between moment. It was expansive, spilling out of theatres into televisions, phones and global stages. ■